Therac 25

By Adam Pettle

A waiting room, the Princess Margaret Hospital. Early in the morning. Alan (22) sits in the waiting room. He has a black, bound journal in his lap; he is trying to write. After a beat or two, Moira enters the waiting room. She grabs a Reader's Digest and sits down in a chair, feigning interest in the magazine. There is a long silence . . .

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *Cancer blossoms like a fleur du mal in the human body.*
ACTOR: *That's a scary fact of life.*
ACTRESS: *Less certain -- and far more delicate -- is the love that flowers in a hospital cancer ward in Therac 25.*
ACTOR: *Alan and Moira, the most unlikely of partners.*
ACTRESS: *From that first mutual look of interest as they wait for their ongoing therapies . .*
ACTOR: *They're a couple destined to alternate between tentative offers of comfort and spiky retreat.*
TOGETHER: *Therac 25 by Adam Pettle*

ALAN: What year is it?

MOIRA: What?

ALAN: The Digest

MOIRA: Oh. *(checking the cover)* Eighty-four.

ALAN: A fine year. The Summer Games in L.A., the arrival of E.T . . . Christ! That's ten years ago already . . . . Now why would they want us to read articles from ten years ago? We're cancer patients, not historians . . . . I'm Alan

MOIRA: Moira

ALAN: So, where's your . . . ?

MOIRA: On my mind.

ALAN: And what number treatment is this?

MOIRA: Nine.

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ALAN: Of?

MOIRA: Twenty-five.

ALAN: Hey! Me too. I've got two today.

MOIRA: Yum. . . . Are you trying to pick me up?

ALAN: What?! No, I mean, no! Christ, I've never even tried in a bar, I mean I just never know what to say, and in a waiting room at the Princess Margaret I think I'd really be out of my league. *(Grabbing his journal)* That could be my book: "One Hundred and One Lines to Pick Up a Cancer Patient" *(He begins writing the idea down in his journal)* *(Pause)*

MOIRA: "Hey, baby! Want to go for some platinum injections?"

ALAN: *(Laughing)* "You know, ah, I don't want to brag, but I've got the lowest white blood cell count in this place."

MOIRA: "I don't know if anyone has ever told you this, but you've got the most scannable skull I have ever . . . " *(OVER THE INTERCOM)* Mr. Feldman to Vault Forty-one. Mr. Feldman.

ALAN: That's me. *(Getting his stuff together)* What are you doing this afternoon?

MOIRA: I have chemo at eleven-thirty.

ALAN: You're doing both! Mon Dieu.

MOIRA: Just for another week. Then my cycle is over.

ALAN: Well do you have plans after chemo? Another one for the book.

MOIRA: Vomiting

ALAN: Can I join you?

MOIRA: You are trying to pick me up.

ALAN: I'm just . . . It's just that I have eight hours in between my two treatment . . . If I go home, I'll fall asleep in front of Geraldo, if I stay down here, I'll wander from coffee shop to coffee shop. We could go for coffee in the four-star cafeteria.

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MOIRA: Why would you want to go out with me? I'm . . . I'm bald.

ALAN: I'm Jewish.

MOIRA: Imagine what our kids would look like.

ALAN: My grandfather. What do you say?

MOIRA: I'll meet you in the cafe at twelve-thirty.

ALAN: Great! Have a good . . . Do you say "Have a good chemo?"

MOIRA: No.

(Alan walks out of the room, Moira closes her eyes and puts her face in her hands. Alan re-enters the room.)

ALAN: Did you say twel . . . ?

MOIRA: What?

ALAN: Sorry, I . . . Are you . . . How are you feeling?

MOIRA: Don't say that.

ALAN: I know – the world's worst question and yet I ask it; it's just –

MOIRA: No! It's not a joke. If you want to know me, you can never ask me that, it's a rule, you understand?

ALAN: Yes. *(Pause)* Do you still want to meet me for coffee?

MOIRA: Maybe I'll be there and maybe I won't.

(SCENE)

(Alan sits in the cafeteria drinking a tea, anxiously looking to the door. After a few beats Moira enters the cafeteria and approaches Alan's table, gingerly)

ALAN: You came.

MOIRA: I decided to forgive you.

ALAN: Thanks. How was . . . ?

MOIRA: Don't ask. *(She takes a pill out of her bad and washes it down with her bottled water.)* So when was your diagnosis?

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ALAN: Late August.

MOIRA: And what was . . . ?

ALAN: Oh, ah . . . a tumor on my thyroid gland which was removed two weeks later, along with eleven cancerous lymph nodes and the nerve attached to my left vocal cord. The tumor was wrapped around the nerve, which was a surprise to me and to Dr Brierly. He spent an hour during my surgery deciding whether to remove the nerve or –

MOIRA: Will you excuse me for a second? *(Before the question is answered, she is up and out)*

ALAN: *(To himself)* I think she's gone to throw up. Is it the chemo, or the smell of the meatloaf? Or me? I wish I could . . . Maybe she wants me to go out there. I can't. Christ, you know most people pick an early move and a bit afterwards for their first date . . . We are not most people.

MOIRA: *(Re-entering the cafeteria)* Sorry. What were you saying? We were talking about your surgery.

ALAN: Right. Ah, gone: thyroid, parathyroid, eleven lymph nodes – enough for a soccer team – the nerve attached to vocal cord, gained a . . . a new pair of eyes. You know, I was hopein they would do something about this nose, but . . . not enough OR time, I guess. Cutbacks, you know? Did you have surgery?

MOIRA: No. It's inoperable. Like your nose. I have a high-grade pineal tumor that resembles meduloblastoma.

ALAN: *(Pause)* So, what do you want to be when you grow up?

MOIRA: Alive.

ALAN: I . . . I hear there's good money in that.

MOIRA: I was in my third year of Sociology. I was thinking about social work.

ALAN: You *are* thinking about social work.

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MOIRA: Whatever. Chris . . . my boyfriend . . . is coming to get me at one-thirty. Do you need a lift somewhere?

ALAN: Oh, no thanks, I've got my car.

MOIRA: Ooooh, he's got a car.

ALAN: Yeah, she's a '79 Gremlin. It was my high school graduation present.

MOIRA: A Gremlin?

ALAN: Yeah, well, I didn't do that well in high school. Do you drive?

MOIRA: I do, but not lately. I mean, you know what they say about morphine and driving.

ALAN: Well, you should give me your number. I mean, I'm coming down here every day, I'd be happy to give you a life if you – *(She starts writing her phone number down and laughing.)* What?

MOIRA: I was just thinking . . . I wonder what's more distasteful: the chemo, or being driven to it in a Gremlin.

ALAN: Eh! Enough with the car. Here, I'm going to give you mine, too. *(He writes down his number, starts to hand it to her, then pulls it back.)* Now no crank calls, OK?

MOIRA: I promise

(SCENE)

(A small Greet Orthodox church beside the hospital)

MOIRA: Thanks for bringing me here. I haven't been in a church in three years.

ALAN: Happy halfway home. Treatment number thirteen, *c'est finis*!

MOIRA: Why do you do that? . . . That French thing at the end of your sentences. If we were married that would be one of those things that would secretly drive me crazy and eventually force me into an adulterous affair.

ALAN: C'est dommage! I think the way that you stare at my hairline when I'm speaking would have me banging the maid long before you had a chance to .

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MOIRA: Banging the maid? Is that what sex is with you? Banging?

ALAN: Do you think this is the place to be discussing this?

MOIRA: No. *(Pause)* If you'd said I would be nailing the maid, then we'd

ALAN: Oh. Nice. Crucifixion jokes, we are in big trouble.

MOIRA: Oh, you're right, I shouldn't mock God, make . . . make jokes about Jesus, I should be grateful for all this great luck I've been having . . . I'm sorry, God, please don't give me locusts or . . . or a brain tumor, or . . .

ALAN: Moira, please –

MOIRA: Excuse me! I'm talking to God. And when I die, please take care of mommy and daddy and my dog Suzie . . .

ALAN: Do you ever wonder why everyone cries when they're born? I men, not everyone cries when they die, right? At least not on TV.

MOIRA: No, they don't. I think you're on to something Nietzsche.

ALAN: I'm not talking about dying tomorrow, it's a long way off, for both of us, but it is inevitable, and . . . and I think we could talk about it.

MOIRA: I don't want to talk about it. . . Your top three.

ALAN: What?

MOIRA: Your top three biggest regrets if you die tomorrow, not that it's going to happen. What are the chances of your cancer recurring, what?! Seventy-five percent it won't.

ALAN: Yes! And you've got a good chance, too. I looked up meduloblastoma, it's treatable! You've got a really good shot at beating this thing!

MOIRA: I think I'm going to throw up. . . No I am going to throw up. *(Moira begins to sing Moonshadow to herself. After a beat or two, she begins to vomit)*

ALAN: Ah . . . is there anything I can do for you?

MOIRA: Sing Moonshadow . . . Cat Stevens, Moonshadow, sing it.

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ALAN: Moira, I . . . I . . . I don't know it. *(Moira puts her hand on Alan's back; Alan moves away)* No, I can't

MOIRA: Can't want?

ALAN: Be touched. I'm sorry I . . . I tried to tell you. It's just that since September, since my surgery, I . . . I have days when I can't be touched, not by hands, not by drugs, not even a hug from my mother. And I need you to know that it's not your hands that are making me nauseous, it's this body . . . How am I supposed to have a relationship? How am I supposed to explain why I'm crying for the ninth night in a row? . . . You know, I don't even like it when someone holds my hand.

MOIRA: I think I'd better go. *(Moira begins walking out, staggering a little. Suddenly she grabs the back of her neck then falls, convulsing in a seizure.)*

ALAN: Oh my God! *(Lights fade)*

(SCENE)

(A hospital room. Moira sits in a hospital bed hooked to an IV. She is staring out the window, Alan enters.

MOIRA: I don't want you here. I want you to leave. It's going to be really embarrassing if I have to call Security – for both of us – so I'm asking you once more to leave.

ALAN: I can't just leave things like this.

MOIRA: Which part of that didn't you understand? Go away!

ALAN: No – you – just let me apologize, OK, and then I'll leave.

MOIRA: Oh! I get it! You think this is your fault. This is a guilt visit. You won't be able to live with yourself thinking you caused the seizure that broke the camel's back.

ALAN: *(simultaneously with "live")* That's not what I'm saying. I just need to talk to you.

MOIRA: You need to talk to me? What could there possible be to talk about? Now get out and don't come back.

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ALAN: "I'm being followed by a moon shadow, moon shadow, moon shadow. I'm leaping and hopping on a moon shadow, moon shadow, moon shadow . . . " *(He has some trouble remembering the words)* "And if I ever lose my eyes, lose my eyes, if I lose. And if I ever lose my eyes, oh way hey hey hey hey hey hey hey hey, I won't have to see again."

MOIRA: It's a joke *(near tears) (pause)*

ALAN: What's happening?

MOIRA: I told you that my tumor resembled meduloblastoma, but what makes it different is that it can travel through the spinal fluid to other parts of the brain and . . . mine has.

ALAN: What does that mean?

MOIRA: That I'm going to die.

ALAN: When?

MOIRA: Soon.

ALAN: Is there anything I can do? *(Moira shakes her head, but then it slowly turns into a nod. She looks at him, reaches down and touches his nose. Alan does not pull away. Moira runs her hand down his face, and then takes his hand and puts it on her chest.)* Moira . . . how are you feeling?

MOIRA: I'm scared.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier

NOTE: Here's a link to Cat Steven's Moonshadow to help with the signing parts:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hr0rDW5j1KU